

Signs of Rheumatoid Arthritis in the Early Stages

Practical NHS-backed advice on signs of rheumatoid arthritis in early stages.

By **Living With Arthritis** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Signs of Rheumatoid Arthritis in the Early Stages

Quick Answer: Early signs of rheumatoid arthritis include symmetrical joint swelling (typically hands, wrists, and feet), morning stiffness lasting more than 30 minutes, persistent fatigue, and warmth or tenderness in small joints. Catching RA early — ideally within 12 weeks of symptoms — leads to significantly better outcomes.

RA often begins subtly. Many people dismiss early signs as tiredness or a minor strain. But early treatment can achieve remission in a significant proportion of patients.

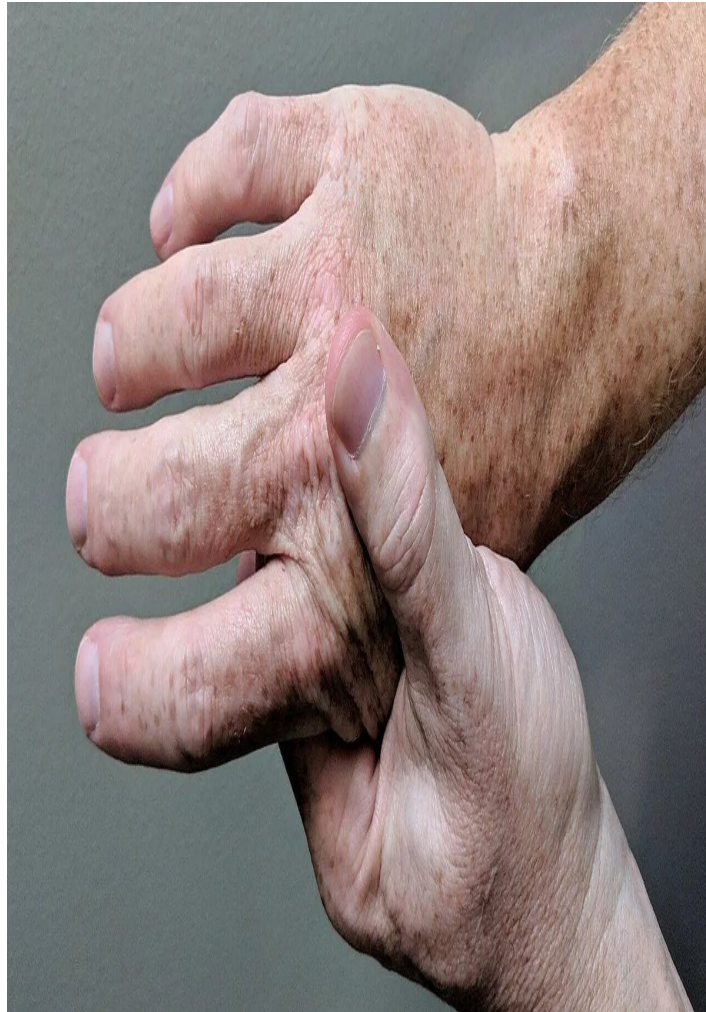
Joint Symptoms to Watch For

RA typically starts in small joints — knuckles, fingers, wrists, and toes. The key distinguishing feature is symmetry: RA usually affects the same joints on both sides simultaneously — both wrists, or knuckles on both hands.

Specific Early Signs

- Swelling, warmth, or tenderness in knuckles or wrists
 - Stiffness worst in the morning or after rest
 - Morning stiffness lasting more than 30 minutes — a key diagnostic marker
 - Difficulty making a tight fist or gripping objects
 - Symmetrical symptoms on both sides of the body
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Whole-Body Symptoms



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Unlike osteoarthritis, RA is a systemic condition. Early RA often causes significant fatigue — a heavy, unrelenting exhaustion that doesn't improve with rest. Low-grade fever, loss of appetite, and a general feeling of being unwell are also common in early RA.

When to See Your GP

See your GP promptly — ideally within two weeks — if you have joint swelling lasting more than six weeks, morning stiffness lasting more than 30 minutes, or symmetrical joint symptoms. NICE guidelines recommend urgent referral to rheumatology when RA is suspected.

Q&A;



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Question: Can early RA be effectively treated if caught quickly? **Short answer:** Yes — treatment started within the first 12 weeks ("the window of opportunity") can achieve remission in a significant proportion of patients and may prevent permanent joint damage.

Question: What blood tests diagnose early RA? **Short answer:** Your GP will check rheumatoid factor (RF), anti-CCP antibodies, CRP, and ESR. Note that 20–30% of RA patients are seronegative — a negative blood test does not rule out RA.

Question: Is joint pain at night a sign of early RA? **Short answer:** Yes — waking with stiff, painful hands or wrists that take more than 30 minutes to loosen up is a classic early RA symptom and warrants urgent GP review.